

# Understanding Your Hearing Loss

Category: Understand Your Hearing

Best for: Newly diagnosed adults, adults considering hearing aids, family members

Evidence level: Professional, public health, and peer-reviewed sources

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## Understanding Your Hearing Loss

### What does it mean to have hearing loss?

Hearing loss means that your ears and hearing system are not picking up sound as clearly or easily as they once did. For some people, sounds may seem softer. For others, speech may sound unclear, muffled, or distorted, even when the speaker is loud enough. This is why many adults with hearing loss say, “I can hear people talking, but I cannot always understand what they are saying.”

Hearing loss is common in adults. It can happen gradually over time, suddenly, or as a result of noise exposure, aging, illness, injury, medications, genetics, or other medical conditions. About 15% of adults in the United States report some trouble hearing, and hearing loss becomes more common with age (National Institute on Deafness and Other Communication Disorders [NIDCD], 2023).

Hearing loss can affect more than your ability to hear sounds. It can affect conversations, relationships, work, safety, energy level, confidence, and participation in daily life. The good news is that hearing loss can often be managed with the right combination of education, communication strategies, hearing technology, medical care when needed, and support from family and friends.

### Why do I hear some sounds but miss words?

Speech is made of many different sounds. Some speech sounds are low-pitched and easier to hear, such as vowel sounds. Other speech sounds are high-pitched and softer, such as /s/, /f/, /th/, /sh/, /t/, and /k/. These high-frequency sounds carry a lot of speech clarity.

Many adults have more difficulty hearing high-frequency sounds. When this happens, speech may seem loud enough but not clear enough. For example, you may hear someone talking, but you may miss the difference between words like “cat,” “cap,” “cast,” or “cash.”

This can be especially difficult in background noise. Restaurants, family gatherings, cars, waiting rooms, and group conversations can make listening harder because your brain has to separate speech from competing sounds. Hearing loss can make this separation more difficult, even when you are paying close attention.

### The three main types of hearing loss

There are three main types of hearing loss: conductive, sensorineural, and mixed (American Speech-Language-Hearing Association [ASHA], n.d.).

## Conductive hearing loss

Conductive hearing loss happens when sound has trouble traveling through the outer ear or middle ear. This may happen because of earwax, fluid behind the eardrum, an ear infection, a hole in the eardrum, or problems with the tiny bones of the middle ear.

Some conductive hearing losses are temporary or medically treatable. Others may need long-term management. If your audiologist suspects a medical cause, they may recommend that you see a physician or an ear, nose, and throat doctor.

## Sensorineural hearing loss

Sensorineural hearing loss happens when there is damage or change in the inner ear, also called the cochlea, or in the hearing nerve pathways. This is one of the most common types of adult hearing loss. It may be related to aging, noise exposure, genetics, certain medications, or medical conditions.

Sensorineural hearing loss is often permanent. It usually cannot be corrected with medication or surgery, but it can often be managed with hearing aids, assistive listening technology, communication strategies, and regular hearing care.

## Mixed hearing loss

Mixed hearing loss means there is both a conductive component and a sensorineural component. In other words, there may be a problem in the outer or middle ear and also a problem in the inner ear or hearing nerve pathway.

Management depends on what is causing each part of the hearing loss. Some people may need medical care first, followed by hearing technology or other support.

## How much hearing loss do I have?

Hearing loss can range from mild to profound. Your audiologist measures hearing using a test called an audiogram. The audiogram shows the softest sounds you can hear at different pitches. It also helps show the type and degree of hearing loss.

In general:

- **Mild hearing loss** may make soft speech, distant speech, and speech in background noise harder to understand.
- **Moderate hearing loss** may make everyday conversation difficult without hearing support.
- **Severe hearing loss** may make speech very difficult to hear without hearing technology.
- **Profound hearing loss** may make it very difficult to hear speech and many environmental sounds without powerful hearing technology or implantable hearing options.

The amount of hearing loss does not tell the whole story. Two people can have similar audiograms but very different real-life experiences. Your daily communication needs, listening environments, word recognition ability, health history, and personal goals all matter.

## Why does hearing loss feel so tiring?

Hearing happens in the ears, but understanding happens in the brain. When sound is unclear, your brain has to work harder to fill in missing pieces. This is called listening effort.

Listening effort can make conversations feel exhausting. You may notice that you feel more tired after meetings, family gatherings, phone calls, appointments, or noisy environments. You may also find yourself avoiding certain situations because listening takes so much energy.

This does not mean you are not trying hard enough. It means your hearing system is receiving an incomplete signal, and your brain is working extra hard to make sense of it.

## How can hearing loss affect daily life?

Hearing loss can affect daily life in many ways. You may notice difficulty:

- Following conversations in restaurants or group settings
- Hearing soft voices, children's voices, or speech from another room
- Understanding speech when people wear masks or turn away
- Hearing on the phone
- Watching TV at a comfortable volume for others
- Participating in work meetings or social events
- Hearing doorbells, alarms, timers, traffic sounds, or announcements
- Feeling confident in conversations

Hearing loss can also affect relationships. Family and friends may think you are ignoring them, not paying attention, or being difficult, when the real issue is that you did not hear clearly. Over time, these misunderstandings can lead to frustration on both sides.

Unaddressed hearing loss has also been associated with social isolation, loneliness, reduced quality of life, and cognitive health concerns (Shukla et al., 2020; World Health Organization, 2026). This does not mean that hearing loss automatically causes these outcomes. It means that hearing is connected to communication, participation, and daily functioning, so it is important to manage hearing loss early and consistently.

## Why early support matters

Many people wait years before getting help for hearing loss. Some adults feel embarrassed. Some feel that their hearing is "not bad enough." Others worry that hearing aids will make them look old or that they will not help.

Getting support early can make daily communication easier and may help reduce listening fatigue. Early support also gives you time to learn what helps you, practice communication strategies, and adjust to hearing technology if it is recommended.

Hearing care is not only about hearing aids. It may include:

- Understanding your hearing test results

- Learning communication strategies
- Involving family or communication partners
- Using captions or phone accessibility tools
- Trying hearing aids or assistive listening devices
- Monitoring changes in hearing over time
- Getting medical evaluation when needed
- Creating a long-term hearing care plan

## What can I do now?

If you have hearing loss, you do not have to manage it alone. The first step is understanding your hearing and how it affects your real life.

You can start by asking yourself:

- Where do I have the most trouble hearing?
- Who do I have the hardest time understanding?
- What situations do I avoid because of hearing difficulty?
- What sounds or conversations matter most to me?
- What would I like to improve first?

These answers can help your audiologist recommend the best plan for you.

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# How to Read Your Audiogram

Category: Understand Your Hearing

Best for: Adults reviewing hearing test results, newly diagnosed adults, family members

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical audiology sources

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## How to Read Your Audiogram

### Why your audiogram matters

An audiogram is a graph that shows how well you hear different sounds. It is one of the main tools audiologists use to understand your hearing. Your audiogram can help show whether you have hearing loss, how much hearing loss you have, which pitches are easier or harder to hear, whether one ear hears better than the other, and whether hearing aids or other support may help.

An audiogram does not explain everything about your hearing, but it gives your audiologist an important starting point. It helps connect your test results to your real-life listening difficulties.

### The two main parts of the audiogram

An audiogram has two main parts: pitch, also called frequency, and loudness, also called intensity.

#### Pitch: low sounds to high sounds

Pitch is measured in hertz, often written as Hz. Low-pitched sounds are on the left side of the audiogram. High-pitched sounds are on the right side. Many adults with hearing loss have more difficulty hearing high-pitched sounds. This can make speech sound unclear because many speech clarity sounds are high-pitched and soft.

You may hear that someone is talking, but miss the difference between words like "see" and "she," "cat" and "cap," "fifteen" and "fifty," or "sat" and "fat." This is one reason people with hearing loss often say, "I can hear, but I cannot understand."

#### Loudness: soft sounds to loud sounds

Loudness is measured in decibels, often written as dB. The top of the audiogram shows very soft sounds. As you move down the graph, sounds become louder. Better hearing is closer to the top.

Your marks on the audiogram show the softest sounds you could hear at each pitch. These marks are called hearing thresholds.

### What do the symbols mean?

Audiograms use different symbols to show how each ear hears. Common symbols include O for the right ear and X for the left ear. Other symbols may show bone-conduction results, masked results, or no-response results.

### Air conduction and bone conduction

Air-conduction testing is usually done with headphones or earphones. It measures how sound travels through the outer ear, middle ear, inner ear, and hearing nerve pathway.

Bone-conduction testing uses a small device placed behind the ear or on the forehead. It sends sound vibrations through the bone directly to the inner ear. If air-conduction results are worse than bone-conduction results, this may suggest that sound is having trouble traveling through the outer or middle ear. Your audiologist may call this an air-bone gap.

## **What type of hearing loss do I have?**

Conductive hearing loss happens when sound has trouble moving through the outer ear or middle ear.

Sensorineural hearing loss happens when there are changes or damage in the inner ear or hearing nerve pathway.

Mixed hearing loss means there is both a conductive part and a sensorineural part.

## **How much hearing loss do I have?**

Audiologists describe hearing loss by degree. General categories may include normal hearing, slight hearing loss, mild hearing loss, moderate hearing loss, moderately severe hearing loss, severe hearing loss, and profound hearing loss. These categories are based on how loud sounds need to be before you hear them.

## **What is word recognition?**

Word recognition testing helps your audiologist understand how clearly your hearing system processes speech when words are loud enough for you to hear. Two people can have similar audiograms but different speech understanding.

## **Why your audiogram does not show everything**

An audiogram is usually measured in a quiet test room using simple tones. Real life is more complicated. You may need to hear speech in background noise, fast talkers, soft voices, multiple speakers, accents, children's voices, speech from another room, phone calls, TV dialogue, or public announcements.

Your audiogram is one piece of the full picture.

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# Why Hearing Loss Affects More Than Hearing

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## Why Hearing Loss Affects More Than Hearing

### Hearing loss is not only about volume

Many people think hearing loss simply means that sounds are not loud enough. That is only part of the story. Hearing loss can also affect how clearly you understand speech, how much effort it takes to listen, how confident you feel in conversations, and how connected you feel to other people.

You may notice that you can hear someone talking, but the words are not clear. You may understand well in a quiet room but struggle in a restaurant, car, meeting, family gathering, or group conversation. You may also feel tired after listening for a long time.

These experiences are common. Hearing loss can affect communication, social participation, quality of life, access to work or community activities, and emotional well-being (World Health Organization [WHO], 2026). The goal of hearing care is not only to help you hear more sound. The goal is to help you communicate, participate, and stay connected.

### Hearing loss can make communication harder

Communication depends on more than hearing that someone is speaking. To understand speech, your brain needs access to a clear sound signal. Hearing loss can make parts of speech softer, unclear, or missing.

This can make everyday communication more difficult, especially when:

- Someone speaks softly
- Someone talks from another room
- The speaker turns away
- More than one person talks at the same time
- There is background noise
- You are tired or distracted
- The room has poor acoustics
- The speaker has an unfamiliar voice or accent

Hearing loss may cause you to ask for repetition, miss details, misunderstand instructions, or pretend you understood when you did not. Over time, this can become frustrating for both the person with hearing loss and their communication partners.



Age-related hearing loss is one of the most common conditions affecting adults as they get older. The National Institute on Deafness and Other Communication Disorders reports that about 15% of American adults report some trouble hearing, and hearing loss becomes more common with age (National Institute on Deafness and Other Communication Disorders [NIDCD], 2023).

## **Hearing loss can increase listening effort**

Hearing happens in the ears, but understanding happens in the brain. When speech is incomplete or unclear, the brain has to work harder to fill in missing information. This extra effort is often called listening effort.

Listening effort can make communication feel tiring. You may notice that you feel worn out after:

- Work meetings
- Phone calls
- Family gatherings
- Medical appointments
- Religious or community events
- Restaurants or noisy places
- Long conversations

This fatigue is not because you are not trying hard enough. It can happen because your hearing system is receiving an incomplete signal, and your brain is using more energy to make sense of speech.

Because listening can become tiring, some adults begin to avoid difficult listening situations. Avoidance may feel easier in the short term, but over time, it can reduce participation in conversations, relationships, and meaningful activities.

## **Hearing loss can affect relationships**

Hearing loss can create misunderstandings between people. Family members or friends may think a person is ignoring them, not paying attention, or being difficult. The person with hearing loss may feel embarrassed, frustrated, left out, or tired of asking people to repeat.

Common relationship challenges include:

- Missing parts of conversations
- Responding incorrectly because words were misunderstood
- Saying “never mind” instead of repeating important information
- Family members speaking from another room
- The television volume being too loud for others
- Avoiding restaurants, gatherings, or group events
- Feeling left out when several people talk at once

These problems are not only caused by the person with hearing loss. Communication is shared. Family members, friends, coworkers, and caregivers can help by facing the person, speaking clearly, reducing background noise when possible, and checking that important information was understood.

## **Hearing loss can affect social participation**

When listening becomes difficult, some adults start avoiding social situations. They may skip gatherings, stay quieter in groups, or stop participating in activities they once enjoyed.

A systematic review by Shukla and colleagues found that hearing loss is associated with loneliness and social isolation in adults (Shukla et al., 2020). This does not mean every adult with hearing loss will become lonely or isolated. It means hearing loss can make communication and social participation harder, especially when it is not addressed.

Social connection matters. Conversations with family, friends, coworkers, and community members are part of daily life. Treating hearing loss and using communication strategies can help reduce barriers to participation.

## **Hearing loss can affect safety and independence**

Hearing also supports awareness of the environment. Depending on the type and degree of hearing loss, some people may have difficulty hearing:

- Doorbells
- Timers
- Smoke alarms
- Car horns
- Sirens
- Approaching vehicles
- Someone calling from another room
- Announcements in public places
- Medical instructions
- Phone calls or emergency alerts

Not every person with hearing loss will have the same safety concerns. The impact depends on the person's hearing levels, lifestyle, home environment, work environment, and use of hearing technology or alerting devices.

For some adults, hearing aids, visual alerts, captioning, phone accessibility tools, and assistive listening devices may improve access to important sounds and information.

## **Hearing loss and emotional well-being**

Hearing loss can affect emotional well-being. Some adults feel embarrassed when they miss words. Some feel frustrated when they have to ask for repetition. Some feel anxious before noisy events because they know listening

will be difficult. Others may feel grief because communication no longer feels as easy as it once did.

These reactions are understandable. Hearing loss can change how a person experiences conversations, relationships, work, and social life.

Emotional responses may include:

- Frustration
- Embarrassment
- Stress
- Listening fatigue
- Reduced confidence
- Worry about misunderstanding others
- Avoidance of difficult listening situations
- Feeling left out in groups

Support can help. This may include audiologic care, communication strategies, family education, hearing technology, assistive listening devices, support groups, and mental health support when needed.

## **Hearing loss and cognitive health: a balanced explanation**

Research has found an association between hearing loss and cognitive health in older adults. The 2024 Lancet Commission on dementia prevention, intervention, and care identifies hearing loss as one of several potentially modifiable risk factors associated with dementia risk (Livingston et al., 2024).

This does not mean hearing loss automatically causes dementia. It also does not mean that every person with hearing loss will develop cognitive decline. The relationship is complex. Many factors affect cognitive health, including age, cardiovascular health, education, social engagement, physical activity, depression, diabetes, smoking, vision loss, and other health conditions.

A balanced way to understand this is:

- Hearing loss can make communication harder.
- Communication difficulty can increase listening effort.
- Listening difficulty may reduce social participation for some people.
- Social isolation and reduced stimulation may affect overall well-being.
- Hearing care may support communication, participation, and quality of life.

Hearing care should not be presented as a fear-based message. It should be presented as a practical way to support daily communication, connection, safety, and long-term well-being.

## **Why treatment and support matter**

Hearing care is not only about hearing aids. Hearing aids may be an important part of the plan, but many adults benefit from a combination of supports.

A hearing care plan may include:

- Hearing aids
- Assistive listening devices
- Captioning tools
- Phone accessibility features
- TV listening technology
- Remote microphones
- Communication strategies
- Family education
- Hearing protection
- Medical referral when needed
- Regular hearing monitoring
- Cochlear implant evaluation when appropriate

The best plan depends on your hearing test results, communication needs, health history, lifestyle, and personal goals.

## **What can you do now?**

You can start by noticing how hearing loss affects your daily life. This helps your audiologist recommend support that fits your real-world needs.

Ask yourself:

- Where do I feel most successful when listening?
- Where do I struggle most?
- Do I avoid any situations because hearing is difficult?
- Do I feel tired after listening?
- Do my family or friends notice communication problems?
- Are phone calls, TV, work meetings, or restaurants difficult?
- What would I most like to improve?

These answers can help turn your hearing test results into a practical care plan.

## **Key Takeaway**

Hearing loss affects more than the ability to hear sound. It can affect speech understanding, listening effort, relationships, social participation, safety, emotional well-being, and quality of life. Hearing care should be supportive, practical, and personalized. The goal is to help you stay connected to the people, places, and activities that matter most.

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# Hearing Aids: What They Can and Cannot Do

Category: Use Your Tools Well

Best for: Adults considering hearing aids, new hearing aid users, family members

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical guideline, and systematic review sources

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## Hearing Aids: What They Can and Cannot Do

### Why this article matters

Hearing aids are one of the most common tools used to manage permanent hearing loss in adults. They can be very helpful, but they are sometimes misunderstood.

Some people expect hearing aids to make hearing “normal” again. Others worry that hearing aids will not help at all. The truth is more balanced: hearing aids can improve access to sound and make communication easier for many adults, but they do not restore normal hearing.

A good hearing aid plan includes realistic expectations, proper fitting, consistent use, follow-up care, and communication strategies. Hearing aids work best when they are part of a complete hearing care plan.

### What are hearing aids?

Hearing aids are small electronic devices that make selected sounds easier to hear. They usually include:

- A microphone that picks up sound
- A processor that adjusts and amplifies sound
- A speaker that sends sound into the ear
- A battery or rechargeable power source

Modern hearing aids can be programmed based on a person’s hearing test results. They may also include features such as directional microphones, noise reduction, feedback management, Bluetooth streaming, rechargeable batteries, smartphone control, and different listening programs.

Hearing aids are not all the same. The best option depends on the person’s hearing test results, ear anatomy, listening needs, technology comfort, budget, dexterity, vision, lifestyle, and personal goals.

### What hearing aids can do

Hearing aids can help many adults hear speech and environmental sounds more clearly. They are designed to improve access to sounds that are difficult to hear because of hearing loss.

Hearing aids may help you:

- Hear soft speech more easily

- Understand speech better in quiet settings
- Notice more environmental sounds
- Reduce the need for others to speak loudly
- Participate more comfortably in conversations
- Hear television or phone audio better when connected to accessories or Bluetooth
- Reduce listening strain in some situations
- Improve communication with family, friends, coworkers, and healthcare providers

A Cochrane systematic review found that hearing aids improve listening ability, everyday participation, and health-related quality of life for adults with mild to moderate hearing loss who seek help for their hearing difficulties (Ferguson et al., 2017).

## **What hearing aids cannot do**

Hearing aids are helpful, but they do not cure hearing loss. They do not repair damaged inner ear cells or restore the hearing system to normal.

Hearing aids cannot:

- Give you perfect hearing
- Completely remove background noise
- Make every word clear in every situation
- Restore normal hearing
- Fix all speech understanding difficulties
- Make distant speech as clear as close speech
- Work well if they are not worn consistently
- Replace communication strategies
- Replace medical evaluation when there are medical warning signs

This does not mean hearing aids have failed. It means hearing aids have limits. Even with well-fit hearing aids, some listening situations may still be difficult, especially restaurants, large groups, fast talkers, poor acoustics, distance, masks, or competing noise.

## **Why hearing aids do not make hearing “normal”**

For many adults, hearing loss involves changes in the inner ear or auditory nerve pathway. When the inner ear is not sending a complete signal to the brain, simply making sound louder may not fully restore clarity.

This is why some people say:

“I can hear better with hearing aids, but I still do not catch everything.”

That experience can be normal. Hearing aids improve access to sound, but the brain still has to interpret the signal. Speech understanding also depends on background noise, distance, room acoustics, visual cues, the speaker's voice, attention, fatigue, and the person's word recognition ability.

Hearing aids are most successful when the person understands both their benefits and their limits.

## **Why background noise is still difficult**

Background noise is one of the most common challenges for adults with hearing loss. Hearing aids can help in many noisy situations, but they cannot completely separate every voice from every background sound.

Noise is difficult because speech and background sounds often happen at the same time. The brain has to decide which sound to focus on. Hearing loss can make that separation harder.

Modern hearing aids may include noise reduction and directional microphone features. These features can improve comfort and may help speech understanding in some situations, but they do not erase all background noise.

You may still need communication strategies, such as:

- Sitting closer to the person you want to hear
- Choosing quieter restaurants
- Sitting with your back to the wall
- Facing the speaker
- Asking people to speak one at a time
- Reducing music or television in the background
- Using a remote microphone when appropriate

Hearing aids help, but strategy still matters.

## **Why hearing aids may sound strange at first**

When you first start wearing hearing aids, everyday sounds may seem different. Some sounds may seem sharp, bright, loud, tinny, or unnatural. Your own voice may also sound different.

This can happen because your brain is hearing sounds it may not have heard clearly for a long time. Sounds such as paper crinkling, water running, footsteps, dishes, car signals, birds, and speech consonants may suddenly become more noticeable.

This adjustment period is common. Many people need time, practice, and follow-up appointments before hearing aids feel natural.

However, hearing aids should not be painfully loud or uncomfortable. If sound is uncomfortable, sharp, distorted, or physically bothersome, you should tell your audiologist. Programming changes may be needed.

## **Why consistent use matters**



Hearing aids usually work best when they are worn consistently during waking hours. If hearing aids are worn only once in a while, the brain has fewer opportunities to adjust to amplified sound.

Consistent use helps you learn:

- What sounds are normal
- Which situations are easier with hearing aids
- Which situations are still difficult
- Whether the programming needs adjustment
- Whether the physical fit is comfortable
- Whether accessories or extra strategies may help

Wearing hearing aids only in the most difficult environments, such as restaurants or large gatherings, can be frustrating. Those environments are hard even for experienced hearing aid users. Daily use in quieter settings can help build comfort before using them in more complex listening situations.

## **Why follow-up appointments are important**

A hearing aid fitting is not usually a one-time event. Follow-up care is important because the first settings may need adjustment after you try the devices in real life.

During follow-up appointments, your audiologist may:

- Adjust loudness or sound quality
- Improve comfort
- Review insertion and removal
- Check physical fit
- Review cleaning and maintenance
- Check for feedback or whistling
- Review phone, television, or Bluetooth use
- Discuss difficult listening situations
- Use verification measures when appropriate
- Update the care plan based on your goals

Real-life feedback is important. Your audiologist needs to know what is working and what is not working.

Useful details to report include:

- Which sounds are too loud
- Which voices are unclear
- Whether your own voice bothers you
- Whether hearing aids feel physically comfortable

- Whether restaurants or meetings are difficult
- Whether the hearing aids are being worn consistently
- Whether you are using phone or TV features successfully

## **Prescription hearing aids and over-the-counter hearing aids**

There are different ways adults may access hearing aids.

### **Prescription hearing aids**

Prescription hearing aids are selected, fit, and programmed by a hearing health professional. They are programmed based on the person's hearing test results and communication needs. They may be recommended for many types and degrees of hearing loss.

Prescription hearing aids are especially important when hearing loss is more complex, asymmetric, severe, associated with medical concerns, or when the person needs professional fitting, verification, counseling, and follow-up.

### **Over-the-counter hearing aids**

Over-the-counter hearing aids are available directly to adults without a prescription. According to NIDCD, over-the-counter hearing aids are intended for adults with perceived mild to moderate hearing loss (National Institute on Deafness and Other Communication Disorders [NIDCD], 2022).

Over-the-counter hearing aids are not intended for children. They are also not appropriate for every adult. Adults with sudden hearing loss, ear pain, drainage, dizziness, one-sided hearing loss, rapidly worsening hearing, or other medical symptoms should seek professional evaluation.

If you are not sure which option is appropriate, an audiologic evaluation can help identify your type and degree of hearing loss and guide safe decision-making.

## **When to seek medical evaluation**

Some hearing-related symptoms should be evaluated medically. You should contact a healthcare provider, audiologist, or ear, nose, and throat specialist if you have:

- Sudden hearing loss
- Hearing loss in only one ear or a major difference between ears
- Ear pain
- Ear drainage
- Dizziness or vertigo
- A feeling of fullness that does not go away
- Ringing or tinnitus in only one ear

- A sudden change in hearing
- A history of ear surgery or ear injury
- Hearing loss after head trauma
- Earwax blockage that you cannot safely manage

Hearing aids can help many people, but they should not be used to ignore medical warning signs.

## **How to know whether hearing aids are helping**

Hearing aid success should be measured by real-life improvement, not just by whether sounds are louder.

You may notice that hearing aids are helping if:

- You ask people to repeat less often
- You understand better in quiet conversations
- You hear more environmental sounds
- You feel more confident in conversations
- You participate more in family or social activities
- You can follow television better with appropriate settings or accessories
- You feel less listening strain in some situations
- Family members notice communication is easier

It is also important to notice what remains difficult. Some situations may require additional tools, such as remote microphones, captions, TV streamers, phone settings, or communication partner strategies.

## **Hearing aids work best with communication strategies**

Hearing aids are important, but they are not the only solution. Communication strategies can make a major difference.

Helpful strategies include:

- Face the person speaking
- Move closer to the speaker
- Reduce background noise when possible
- Ask for rephrasing instead of only repetition
- Confirm important details
- Use captions for television or video calls
- Use written instructions for medical or work information
- Tell others what helps you hear better

- Choose quieter seating in restaurants
- Use assistive listening technology when needed

The goal is not to make the person with hearing loss do all the work. Communication works best when both the listener and communication partners make changes.

## **Common myths about hearing aids**

### **Myth: Hearing aids make hearing normal.**

Hearing aids improve access to sound, but they do not restore normal hearing.

### **Myth: Hearing aids should only be worn when hearing is difficult.**

Hearing aids usually work best with consistent daily use.

### **Myth: Hearing aids remove all background noise.**

Hearing aids may reduce or manage some noise, but they cannot remove all background noise.

### **Myth: If hearing aids do not sound perfect right away, they will never work.**

Many people need time, practice, and follow-up adjustments.

### **Myth: Hearing aids are only for older adults.**

Adults of many ages may use hearing aids, depending on their hearing loss and communication needs.

### **Myth: Hearing aids replace communication strategies.**

Hearing aids and communication strategies work best together.

## **What to expect from a strong hearing aid plan**

A strong hearing aid plan should include:

- A complete hearing evaluation
- A discussion of your listening goals
- Device selection based on your hearing and lifestyle
- Realistic expectations
- Proper physical fit
- Programming based on your hearing results
- Verification when appropriate
- Counseling on use and care

- Follow-up appointments
- Troubleshooting support
- Communication strategies
- Discussion of accessories when needed

You should feel comfortable asking questions. Hearing aid care is a process, not a single appointment.

## Key Takeaway

Hearing aids can help many adults communicate more easily and participate more fully in daily life. They can improve access to speech and everyday sounds, but they do not restore normal hearing or remove all background noise. The best results usually come from consistent use, proper fitting, follow-up care, realistic expectations, and communication strategies.

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# **Your First Month with Hearing Aids**

Category: Use Your Tools Well

Best for: New hearing aid users, adults preparing for a hearing aid fitting, family members

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical guideline, and systematic review sources

Last reviewed: May 2026

## **Your First Month with Hearing Aids**

### **Why the first month matters**

The first month with hearing aids is an adjustment period. Hearing aids can improve access to speech and everyday sounds, but they do not make hearing normal. Many adults need time, practice, and follow-up care before hearing aids feel natural.

During the first month, your goals are to learn how to use your hearing aids, build a consistent wearing routine, notice what sounds better, notice what is still difficult, identify comfort or sound-quality concerns, practice communication strategies, and prepare useful feedback for your audiologist.

### **Hearing aids may sound different at first**

Some sounds may seem louder, sharper, brighter, or more noticeable than you expected. Your own voice may also sound different. You may suddenly notice paper crinkling, dishes clinking, water running, footsteps, air conditioning, car signals, birds, clothing brushing against the microphone, chewing, swallowing, and speech sounds like /s/, /f/, /sh/, and /t/.

This does not automatically mean something is wrong. If you have had hearing loss for a while, your brain may not have received certain sounds clearly for a long time. However, sound should not be painful or intolerable. If your hearing aids are painfully loud, physically uncomfortable, distorted, or causing significant irritation, contact your audiologist.

### **Wear them consistently, but build up safely if needed**

Consistent use is important. Hearing aids usually work best when they are worn regularly during waking hours. Some people can wear hearing aids most of the day right away. Others may need to build up gradually.

Try not to save your hearing aids only for the hardest situations, such as restaurants or large family gatherings. Those environments are challenging, even for experienced hearing-aid users.

### **Start with easier listening situations**

Practice in quiet, familiar places first. Try talking with one person at home, watching television at a comfortable volume, listening to familiar voices, taking a short walk in a quiet area, reading aloud, and noticing everyday household sounds.

### **Background noise may still be difficult**

Hearing aids can help with speech and environmental sounds, but they cannot remove all background noise. In noise, you may still need strategies such as sitting close, facing the speaker, choosing quieter seating, asking people to speak one at a time, using captions, or asking about a remote microphone.

## **Follow-up appointments are part of the process**

A hearing-aid fitting is usually not the final step. Follow-up appointments are important because real-life listening gives information that cannot always be predicted in the clinic. Follow-up care is a normal part of successful hearing-aid use.

## **Keep track of what works and what does not**

Bring specific examples to your audiologist. Examples include: "My own voice sounds hollow," "Dishes and paper are too sharp," "Restaurants are still very hard," "The left hearing aid feels loose," or "Phone calls are clearer, but video calls are difficult."

## **Learn basic care and troubleshooting**

Ask your audiologist how to put the hearing aids in, remove them safely, tell right and left apart, charge them or change batteries, clean them, change wax guards if appropriate, store them safely, and use the app or volume control.

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# Simple Communication Strategies That Work

Category: Communicate With Confidence

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, hearing aid users, family members, communication partners

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical guideline, and peer-reviewed sources

Last reviewed: May 2026

## Simple Communication Strategies That Work

### Why communication strategies matter

Hearing aids and other hearing technologies can be very helpful, but they do not solve every listening problem. Communication strategies are practical ways to make conversation easier. They can help you hear more clearly, reduce listening effort, prevent misunderstandings, and feel more confident asking for what you need.

### Strategy 1: Face the person speaking

Seeing the speaker's face can help you understand speech. Helpful phrase: "Could you please face me when you speak? It helps me understand you better."

### Strategy 2: Get the speaker's attention before starting

Ask people to say your name first, make sure you are looking, avoid important conversations from another room, and pause until you are ready to listen.

### Strategy 3: Move closer to the speaker

Distance makes listening harder. Helpful phrase: "I hear better when I am closer. Could we sit over here?"

### Strategy 4: Reduce background noise when possible

Turn off the television during conversation, lower music, close a door or window, move away from kitchen noise, choose quieter tables, and ask people to speak one at a time.

### Strategy 5: Ask for rephrasing, not just repetition

Try "Can you say that another way?" or "I missed the last part. Could you rephrase it?"

### Strategy 6: Repeat back important information

Repeating back information helps confirm that you understood correctly. Helpful phrase: "Let me repeat that back to make sure I understood."

### Strategy 7: Use written support for important details



Use notes, text messages, email summaries, printed instructions, captions, patient portals, meeting agendas, and calendar reminders.

### **Strategy 8: Plan ahead for difficult listening situations**

Before a difficult listening situation, ask where you should sit, who you most need to hear, whether captions or written information are available, and whether a remote microphone would help.

### **Strategy 9: Be specific about what helps**

Instead of saying "I can't hear you," try "Please face me," "Can you slow down a little?" or "Can you send me the address by text?"

### **Strategy 10: Teach communication partners what helps**

Communication is shared. Family, friends, coworkers, and healthcare providers can help by facing you, speaking clearly, reducing background noise, rephrasing, writing down important details, and being patient.

### **Strategy 11: Use captions and technology when helpful**

Helpful tools may include television captions, video call captions, smartphone live caption tools, captioned telephone services, text messaging, hearing aid streaming, remote microphones, TV streamers, and assistive listening systems.

### **Strategy 12: Use repair phrases instead of pretending**

Examples include: "I missed that," "Can you say that another way?" "Can you repeat the number?" "Can you write that down?" and "Can we move somewhere quieter?"

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# How Family and Friends Can Help

Category: Communicate With Confidence

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, spouses/partners, adult children, caregivers, friends

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical guideline, and peer-reviewed sources

Last reviewed: May 2026

## How Family and Friends Can Help

### Why family and friends matter

Hearing loss affects conversations, routines, relationships, and shared activities. Family and friends can make a major difference. Small communication changes can reduce frustration and help the person with hearing loss stay included in everyday conversations.

### Hearing loss is not selective listening

A person may hear well in one situation and poorly in another because listening depends on noise, distance, lighting, room acoustics, speaker voice, visual cues, and fatigue.

### I can hear you, but I cannot understand you

Many adults with hearing loss can hear that someone is talking but cannot clearly understand the words. Shouting usually does not solve the problem and may distort speech. Clear speech, facing the listener, reduced noise, and rephrasing are often more helpful.

### What not to do

- Do not speak from another room
- Do not turn away while talking
- Do not shout
- Do not repeat the same unclear word over and over
- Do not say "never mind"
- Do not assume hearing aids fix every situation

### What helps most

- Get attention first
- Face the listener
- Speak clearly
- Move closer

- Reduce background noise
- Rephrase when needed
- Speak one at a time
- Write down important details
- Be patient and respectful

## **Involve family in hearing care when appropriate**

Some adults benefit from bringing a communication partner to audiology appointments. The person with hearing loss should decide who they want involved.

## **Key Takeaway**

Communication improves when family and friends face the listener, speak clearly, reduce background noise, rephrase rather than saying "never mind," and support hearing technology without criticism.

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# Hearing Better in Background Noise

Category: Communicate With Confidence

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, hearing aid users, adults struggling in restaurants/groups, family members

Evidence level: Professional, public health, clinical guideline, systematic review, and peer-reviewed sources

Last reviewed: May 2026

## Hearing Better in Background Noise

### Why background noise is so difficult

Many adults with hearing loss say that background noise is their hardest listening situation. You may hear fairly well in a quiet room but struggle in restaurants, family gatherings, cars, meetings, waiting rooms, or group conversations.

Hearing aids can help many adults hear better, but even well-fit hearing aids do not remove all background noise. Noise, distance, room echo, multiple speakers, and fast conversation can still make speech difficult to understand.

### Hearing aids help, but they have limits

Hearing aids improve access to speech and everyday sounds, but they do not restore normal hearing and do not completely separate speech from background noise in every situation.

### Noise is not the only problem

Several factors can make speech harder to understand: distance, room echo, multiple speakers, poor lighting, fast speech, masks or covered mouths, fatigue, unfamiliar voices, and topic changes.

### Start with the listening environment

Turn down the television, lower music, move away from kitchens or speakers, choose quieter rooms, close windows or doors, improve lighting, sit away from echo-heavy areas, ask people to speak one at a time, and move closer to the person you want to hear.

### Choose better seating

In restaurants, meetings, and community events, try to sit near the person you most want to hear, where you can see faces clearly, away from speakers or kitchens, with your back to a wall when possible, in a well-lit area, and near the front for presentations.

### Ask for rephrasing

In background noise, repeating the same words may not be enough. Try: "I heard part of that. Can you say it another way?"

### Confirm important information

Repeat back important information. "So dinner is at 6:30, correct?" "You said the medication is once a day?" "Let me repeat that back to make sure I understood."

## **Consider remote microphones and assistive listening devices**

A remote microphone is a small microphone placed near the person speaking. The sound is sent directly to the listener's hearing aids, cochlear implant processor, receiver, or other listening device.

## **Restaurant strategies**

Choose a quieter restaurant, avoid peak hours, ask for a quiet table, look for booths or corner seating, avoid tables near the kitchen or speakers, sit near the person you most want to hear, sit with your back to the wall, ask people to speak one at a time, and consider a remote microphone when appropriate.

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# Helpful Technology for Phone, TV, and Daily Life

Category: Use Your Tools Well

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, hearing aid users, adults struggling with phone/TV/alerts/public spaces, family members

Evidence level: Professional, public health, systematic review, and peer-reviewed sources

Last reviewed: May 2026

## Helpful Technology for Phone, TV, and Daily Life

### Why hearing technology is more than hearing aids

Hearing aids can be very helpful, but they are not the only tools available for adults with hearing loss. Some listening situations are difficult because of distance, background noise, poor room acoustics, unclear speech, or limited visual cues. In these situations, additional technology may help.

Assistive listening technology can support communication in specific daily situations, such as phone calls, television, meetings, appointments, restaurants, group conversations, religious services, alarms, and emergency alerts.

The goal is not to use every device. The goal is to choose the tools that match your real-life needs.

### What is assistive listening technology?

Assistive listening technology includes devices and tools that help people with hearing loss communicate, hear speech more clearly, receive alerts, or access spoken information in another way.

Some tools work with hearing aids. Some work without hearing aids. Some are built into smartphones, televisions, computers, or public spaces.

Examples include:

- Remote microphones
- TV streamers
- Bluetooth hearing-aid streaming
- Captioned phones
- Smartphone captioning tools
- Video-call captions
- Alerting devices
- Vibrating alarms
- Doorbell alerts
- Smoke alarm alerts

- Public assistive listening systems
- Telecoil or hearing loop systems
- FM or digital wireless systems
- Speech-to-text apps

Assistive technology is not a sign that hearing aids failed. It is part of a complete communication plan.

## **Why hearing aids may not be enough in every situation**

Hearing aids improve access to sound, but they cannot remove every listening barrier. Background noise, distance, room echo, and multiple speakers can still make communication difficult.

For example:

- A hearing aid may help you hear your spouse at home but not clearly hear a speaker across a large room.
- A hearing aid may help with conversation in quiet but not fully solve restaurant noise.
- A hearing aid may help with television volume but not always make dialogue clear.
- A hearing aid may help with phone calls but may still need Bluetooth, captions, or streaming support.

Assistive technology can sometimes improve the signal by bringing the speaker's voice or media sound closer to your ears or hearing devices.

## **Remote microphones**

A remote microphone is a small microphone placed near the person speaking. The microphone sends the speaker's voice directly to your hearing aids, cochlear implant processor, receiver, or other listening device.

Remote microphones can be helpful when:

- The speaker is far away
- There is background noise
- You are in a meeting
- You are in a restaurant
- You are in a car
- You are attending a lecture
- You are at a religious or community event
- You are trying to hear one main speaker

A remote microphone may be clipped to the speaker's clothing, placed on a table, or passed between speakers depending on the device.

Remote microphones do not make every situation perfect, but they can improve access to speech when distance and noise are the main problems.

## When to ask about a remote microphone

Ask your audiologist about a remote microphone if you often struggle in:

- Restaurants
- Family gatherings
- Work meetings
- Medical appointments
- Religious services
- Classes or lectures
- Car conversations
- Group conversations
- Noisy places where one person is the main speaker

You can ask:

“Would a remote microphone help in the situations where my hearing aids are not enough?”

You should also ask whether the remote microphone is compatible with your hearing aids, cochlear implant, smartphone, or receiver.

## Television listening tools

Many adults with hearing loss have difficulty understanding television dialogue. Turning up the volume may help the person with hearing loss, but it may be uncomfortable for others in the home. Also, louder does not always mean clearer.

Television listening options may include:

- TV streamers that send sound directly to hearing aids
- Wireless TV headphones
- Bluetooth streaming, depending on the television and hearing aids
- Closed captions
- Sound bars or speakers designed to improve dialogue clarity
- Personal amplifiers
- Adjusting television audio settings, such as dialogue enhancement when available

Captions can be especially helpful because they give visual access to spoken information. Many people benefit from using both sound and captions together.

Helpful question for your audiologist:

“What is the best TV listening option for my hearing aids and home setup?”



## Phone call options

Phone calls can be difficult because you cannot see the speaker's face. Sound quality may also vary depending on the phone, connection, speaker, background noise, and hearing technology.

Helpful phone options may include:

- Bluetooth streaming to hearing aids
- Speakerphone in a quiet room
- Captioned telephone services
- Smartphone live caption features
- Video calls with captions
- Text messaging for important details
- Hearing-aid phone programs
- Telecoil-compatible phones when appropriate
- Adjusting phone volume or audio settings

For important information, such as appointments, addresses, instructions, or medication details, written confirmation can reduce mistakes.

Helpful phrase:

“Can you text or email that information to me so I have it correct?”

## Video calls and online meetings

Video calls can be easier than regular phone calls because you may be able to see the speaker's face. However, they can still be difficult if the audio is poor, speakers talk over one another, or captions are not available.

Helpful video-call strategies include:

- Turn on captions when available
- Use headphones or hearing-aid streaming
- Ask speakers to use a microphone
- Ask participants to speak one at a time
- Keep cameras on when possible
- Ask for an agenda before the meeting
- Request written follow-up after important meetings
- Reduce background noise in your own room
- Use chat for names, numbers, links, or instructions

Helpful phrase:

“Could we turn on captions and have one person speak at a time?”

## **Captioning tools**

Captions provide written access to spoken language. They can help with television, videos, phone calls, video calls, meetings, public presentations, and some live conversations.

Captioning options may include:

- Television captions
- Movie captions
- Video-call captions
- Smartphone live captions
- Captioned telephone services
- Speech-to-text apps
- Meeting transcription tools
- Public event captioning when available

Captions may not be perfect. Automatic captions can make mistakes, especially with background noise, accents, technical words, names, or fast speech. Still, captions can provide helpful support and reduce listening effort.

Captions are most useful when they are used along with good communication strategies, clear sound, and visual access to the speaker.

## **Alerting devices for safety and independence**

Hearing loss can make some warning sounds or household alerts harder to detect. Alerting devices can help by using flashing lights, vibration, louder sound, or smartphone alerts.

Alerting devices may connect to:

- Doorbells
- Telephones
- Alarm clocks
- Smoke alarms
- Carbon monoxide alarms
- Baby monitors
- Timers
- Security systems
- Weather alerts
- Emergency notifications

Some devices send alerts to a phone, smartwatch, vibrating pad, lamp, or visual signal.

These tools may be especially helpful for people who do not reliably hear alarms, doorbells, or emergency sounds.

Important note: safety devices should be selected carefully. Smoke alarms and carbon monoxide alarms should meet current safety standards and be installed according to manufacturer and local safety guidance.

## **Public assistive listening systems**

Some public spaces have assistive listening systems that send sound from a microphone or sound system to a listener's hearing device or receiver.

These systems may be available in:

- Theaters
- Places of worship
- Auditoriums
- Classrooms
- Lecture halls
- Meeting rooms
- Museums
- Airports
- Public service counters
- Community centers

Types of public assistive listening systems may include:

- Hearing loop systems
- FM systems
- Infrared systems
- Digital wireless systems

Some systems work with a telecoil inside a hearing aid or cochlear implant processor. Others require a separate receiver or headset.

If you are not sure whether your hearing aids have a telecoil, ask your audiologist.

Helpful phrase:

“Do you have an assistive listening system available?”

## **Telecoil and hearing loops**

A telecoil, sometimes called a T-coil, is a small part inside some hearing aids and cochlear implant processors. It can connect with hearing loop systems in some public places.

When a hearing loop is available and your telecoil is activated, sound from the room's microphone system may be sent directly to your hearing device. This can improve access to speech in certain public settings.

Not all hearing aids have telecoils, and not all public places have hearing loops. If this is important for your daily life, ask your audiologist whether a telecoil is available and appropriate for your hearing devices.

Questions to ask:

- Do my hearing aids have a telecoil?
- Is the telecoil activated?
- How do I switch to the telecoil program?
- Where might I use it?
- Are there hearing loops in places I visit often?

## Smartphone accessibility tools

Smartphones can provide many helpful accessibility features. Depending on the phone and hearing devices, options may include:

- Hearing-aid streaming
- Live captions
- Sound recognition alerts
- Text-to-speech or speech-to-text tools
- Visual or vibration alerts
- Amplified ringtone or vibration settings
- Bluetooth connections
- Hearing device control apps
- Video calls
- Text messaging
- Emergency alerts

Smartphone tools vary by brand, model, software version, and hearing device compatibility. Ask your audiologist to help you identify which features match your hearing aids and communication needs.

## Choosing the right tool for the problem

The best tool depends on the listening problem.

If the problem is **television**, consider:

- Captions
- TV streamer

- Wireless headphones
- Dialogue-enhancing settings
- Hearing-aid streaming

If the problem is **phone calls**, consider:

- Bluetooth streaming
- Captioned phone service
- Smartphone captions
- Video calls
- Written follow-up

If the problem is **restaurants or groups**, consider:

- Remote microphone
- Hearing-aid noise program
- Seating strategies
- Rephrasing and communication strategies

If the problem is **meetings**, consider:

- Captions
- Remote microphone
- Written agenda
- Meeting notes
- Assistive listening system

If the problem is **safety alerts**, consider:

- Visual alerts
- Vibrating alerts
- Smartphone alerts
- Smoke and carbon monoxide alerting systems

If the problem is **public spaces**, consider:

- Telecoil
- Hearing loops
- FM or infrared receivers
- Captions when available

## Questions to ask your audiologist

Your audiologist can help you decide which technology fits your hearing loss, hearing devices, lifestyle, and budget.

Ask:

- What technology works with my hearing aids?
- Do my hearing aids connect to my phone?
- Do my hearing aids connect to a TV streamer?
- Would a remote microphone help me?
- Do I have a telecoil?
- How do I use public assistive listening systems?
- What captioning tools do you recommend?
- What can help me hear phone calls better?
- What can help me hear television better?
- What alerting devices should I consider?
- Are there lower-cost options?
- Can you show me how to use the device before I buy it?
- Can I try it in the clinic?

Technology is most helpful when it is matched to a real problem and taught clearly.

## **Before buying hearing technology**

Before buying a device, consider:

- What problem am I trying to solve?
- Does it work with my hearing aids or phone?
- Is it easy for me to use?
- Does it require charging?
- Does it need Wi-Fi, Bluetooth, or an app?
- Can I return it if it does not help?
- Is there customer support?
- Will my audiologist help me set it up?
- Does it fit my budget?
- Is there a simpler option?

A more expensive tool is not always the best tool. The best tool is the one that solves your specific problem and is easy enough to use consistently.

# Key Takeaway

Hearing aids are important, but they are not the only tools available. Assistive listening technology can help with phone calls, television, meetings, restaurants, alerts, public spaces, and daily communication. The best choice depends on your hearing needs, lifestyle, hearing devices, and goals. Ask your audiologist which tools are most appropriate for the situations where you struggle most.

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# Hearing Loss at Work and in Public Places

Category: Communicate With Confidence

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, hearing aid users, working adults, students, family members, communication partners

Evidence level: Professional, public health, government, workplace-accommodation, and clinical guideline sources

Last reviewed: May 2026

## Hearing Loss at Work and in Public Places

### Why work and public places can be difficult

Hearing loss can affect more than conversations at home. Many adults also notice difficulty at work, school, appointments, meetings, restaurants, community events, religious services, theaters, stores, airports, and other public places.

These situations can be harder because they often include:

- Background noise
- Distance from the speaker
- Multiple people talking
- Fast conversations
- Poor lighting
- Room echo
- Unfamiliar voices
- Public announcements
- Phone calls
- Video calls
- Masks or covered mouths
- Important information that is only spoken once

This can be stressful because work and public settings often involve information that matters: instructions, schedules, safety information, medical guidance, customer conversations, meeting details, names, numbers, or directions.

The goal is not to avoid these places. The goal is to plan ahead, use communication strategies, use the right technology, and ask for support when needed.

### Hearing loss is different in every setting



You may hear well in one place but struggle in another. This does not mean your hearing loss is inconsistent or that you are not trying.

Listening depends on the environment. A quiet office is different from a busy meeting room. A one-on-one conversation is different from a group discussion. A small clinic room is different from a noisy waiting room. A phone call is different from a video call with captions.

Common listening barriers include:

- The speaker is far away.
- The speaker turns away.
- People talk over one another.
- The room is noisy.
- The sound system is unclear.
- The lighting is poor.
- The information is complex.
- You cannot see the speaker's face.
- You are tired from listening.

Understanding the problem helps you choose the right solution.

## **Work communication challenges**

Adults with hearing loss may notice challenges during:

- Staff meetings
- One-on-one supervision
- Phone calls
- Video calls
- Trainings
- Customer or patient interactions
- Group discussions
- Safety briefings
- Public announcements
- Conversations in noisy work areas
- Conversations with masks or barriers
- Informal conversations in break rooms
- Fast changes in schedule or instructions

These challenges may affect confidence, listening effort, and accuracy. They may also lead to misunderstandings if coworkers do not understand how hearing loss affects speech clarity.

A helpful first step is to identify exactly where communication breaks down. For example, “I cannot hear at work” is broad. “I miss details in staff meetings when people speak from across the room” is more specific and easier to address.

## **School, training, and continuing education settings**

Adults with hearing loss may also need support in school, training programs, certification courses, workshops, or continuing education.

Common challenges include:

- Hearing instructors from a distance
- Understanding speech in large rooms
- Following group discussion
- Hearing classmates’ questions
- Listening while taking notes
- Understanding videos without captions
- Following online lectures
- Hearing in labs, clinics, or hands-on settings

Helpful supports may include:

- Captions
- Written outlines
- Slides or handouts in advance
- Preferential seating
- Assistive listening devices
- Remote microphones
- Permission to record when allowed
- Written summaries
- Clear turn-taking during group discussion
- Accessible video materials

The best support depends on the setting and the person’s specific listening needs.

## **Healthcare appointments**

Healthcare appointments can be especially important because missed information may affect follow-up care, medication instructions, testing, referrals, or treatment decisions.

Adults with hearing loss may benefit from:

- Telling the clinic that they have hearing loss
- Asking the provider to face them
- Asking for written instructions
- Repeating back key information
- Bringing a communication partner if desired
- Using captions or speech-to-text tools when appropriate
- Asking for a printed visit summary
- Using the patient portal for follow-up instructions
- Requesting assistive communication support when needed

Helpful phrases include:

- “I have hearing loss. Please face me when you speak.”
- “Can you write down the main instructions?”
- “Let me repeat that back to make sure I understood.”
- “Could you send the instructions through the patient portal?”
- “Can my family member join so they can help me remember the details?”

## **Public places and community settings**

Public places can be challenging because the environment is often outside your control. There may be noise, distance, crowds, unclear sound systems, or limited seating options.

Difficult public settings may include:

- Theaters
- Airports
- Train stations
- City offices
- Banks
- Restaurants
- Community centers
- Places of worship
- Museums

- Court or government buildings
- Stores
- Public service counters
- Emergency or safety settings

Helpful strategies include:

- Ask whether assistive listening devices are available.
- Ask for written information.
- Use captions when available.
- Sit close to the speaker.
- Choose a seat where you can see faces.
- Ask staff to face you when speaking.
- Use a phone note or text if speech is unclear.
- Ask for repetition or rephrasing.
- Confirm important information before leaving.

A helpful phrase is:

“Do you have an assistive listening system or written information available?”

## **Communication access and auxiliary aids**

In some public settings, communication access may involve auxiliary aids or services. ADA.gov explains that effective communication rules are intended to make sure people with hearing, vision, or speech disabilities can communicate with, receive information from, and convey information to covered entities.

Examples of auxiliary aids and services may include:

- Qualified interpreters
- Note takers
- Written materials
- Assistive listening systems
- Captioning
- Telecommunications relay services
- Video remote interpreting in some situations
- Other tools that support effective communication

The appropriate aid depends on the person’s communication needs, the setting, and the type of information being shared.

This article does not give legal advice. If you need specific legal guidance, consult official ADA resources, your workplace human resources department, disability services, or another qualified resource.

## **Workplace accommodations**

Workplace support should match the person's job tasks and communication needs. The Job Accommodation Network notes that accommodation needs for employees who are deaf or hard of hearing vary depending on individual needs, preferences, and job requirements.

Possible workplace supports may include:

- Written instructions
- Meeting agendas
- Meeting notes or summaries
- Captions for video meetings
- Captioned phone options
- Assistive listening devices
- Remote microphones
- Visual or vibrating alerts
- Quiet workspace when possible
- Preferential seating in meetings
- Clear turn-taking during discussions
- Email follow-up after verbal instructions
- Modified communication procedures
- Training for coworkers on communication strategies
- Access to interpreters or captioning when appropriate

Not every person needs every accommodation. The most effective plan is specific to the job and the listening situation.

## **How to ask for support at work**

Some people feel uncomfortable asking for support at work. A clear, specific request often works better than a general statement.

Instead of saying:

“I cannot hear well at work.”

Try:

“I have difficulty understanding speech in staff meetings when people speak from across the room. It would help if I could sit near the speaker and receive meeting notes or an agenda.”

Other examples:

- “Phone calls are difficult for me. Could we use email summaries for important details?”
- “I understand better when I can see the speaker’s face. Could we keep cameras on during virtual meetings when possible?”
- “I miss information when several people speak at once. Could we use one-speaker-at-a-time turn-taking in meetings?”
- “I have difficulty hearing announcements. Is there a way to receive alerts by text or email?”
- “I use hearing aids, but large meetings are still difficult. Could I ask about captions or an assistive listening option?”

The goal is to describe the barrier and suggest a practical solution.

## **Meeting strategies**

Meetings can be difficult because people may speak quickly, sit far away, turn away, interrupt, or talk over one another.

Before the meeting:

- Ask for an agenda.
- Ask for written materials in advance.
- Sit near the main speaker.
- Choose a seat where you can see faces.
- Ask whether captions are available.
- Bring hearing technology or a remote microphone if appropriate.
- Ask for a quiet room when possible.

During the meeting:

- Ask people to speak one at a time.
- Ask speakers to face the group.
- Confirm important details.
- Ask for clarification when needed.
- Use captions or notes.
- Ask for names or numbers to be written down.

After the meeting:

- Ask for notes or a summary.

- Confirm action items by email.
- Add deadlines to a calendar.
- Follow up if anything was unclear.

Helpful phrase:

“Could we send out a brief summary of decisions and next steps after the meeting?”

## **Phone and video-call strategies**

Phone calls are difficult because visual cues are missing. Video calls may be easier because you can see the speaker’s face, but audio quality and turn-taking can still be problems.

Helpful phone strategies include:

- Use hearing-aid streaming if available.
- Use speakerphone in a quiet room if helpful.
- Use captioned phone services if appropriate.
- Ask for important details by text or email.
- Repeat back names, numbers, and times.
- Schedule important calls when you are not rushed.

Helpful video-call strategies include:

- Turn on captions when available.
- Use headphones or hearing-aid streaming.
- Ask people to mute when not speaking.
- Ask people to speak one at a time.
- Keep cameras on when possible.
- Use chat for names, links, numbers, or instructions.
- Ask for meeting notes afterward.

Helpful phrase:

“Could you put that number or date in the chat so I have it correctly?”

## **Safety information at work and in public**

Some adults with hearing loss may miss spoken warnings, alarms, announcements, or emergency instructions. This depends on the person’s hearing, devices, environment, and the type of signal.

Possible supports include:

- Visual alerts

- Vibrating alerts
- Written safety instructions
- Text or email emergency alerts
- Captioned safety videos
- Buddy systems for emergency drills
- Clear evacuation instructions
- Accessible public announcements when available
- Assistive listening systems in public venues

If you are concerned about hearing safety information at work, talk with your supervisor, safety officer, human resources department, disability services office, or audiologist.

## **Protect your hearing in noisy workplaces**

Some workplaces are loud enough to increase the risk of noise-induced hearing loss. NIDCD explains that noise-induced hearing loss can occur when sounds are too loud, even briefly, or when loud sound exposure lasts a long time. Loud sound can damage sensitive structures in the inner ear.

If you work around loud noise, ask about hearing protection and workplace hearing conservation procedures. You may need:

- Earplugs
- Earmuffs
- Custom hearing protection
- Noise monitoring
- Hearing checks
- Training on safe sound exposure
- Breaks from loud noise when possible

If you already have hearing loss, protecting the hearing you have is especially important.

## **Self-advocacy scripts**

Self-advocacy means clearly explaining what helps you communicate. It does not mean being difficult or demanding. It means helping others communicate with you more effectively.

Useful scripts include:

- “I have hearing loss. Please face me when you speak.”
- “I understand better when one person speaks at a time.”
- “Could you write that down for me?”



- “Could you send that by email so I have the details?”
- “I missed the last part. Could you rephrase it?”
- “Can we move away from the noise?”
- “Could you turn on captions?”
- “Could you put the date and time in the chat?”
- “Please do not give important information from another room.”
- “I want to make sure I understood correctly. Let me repeat that back.”

The more specific your request, the easier it is for others to help.

## Make a personal access plan

A personal access plan is a simple list of what helps you communicate in different places.

Your plan may include:

- At work, I need captions for video meetings.
- In medical appointments, I need written instructions.
- In restaurants, I need quieter seating.
- In public events, I ask about assistive listening systems.
- In meetings, I sit near the speaker.
- For phone calls, I ask for important details by text or email.
- For safety alerts, I need visual or vibrating alerts.

You can share your plan with family, coworkers, healthcare providers, or others when appropriate.

## Key Takeaway

Hearing loss can make work, school, appointments, meetings, and public places more difficult, especially when there is noise, distance, poor acoustics, or important spoken information. Planning ahead, using communication strategies, asking for written support, using captions or assistive technology, and requesting appropriate communication access can help adults with hearing loss participate more confidently and accurately.

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# The Emotional Side of Hearing Loss

Category: Live Well Long-Term

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, new hearing aid users, family members, communication partners

Evidence level: Professional, public health, systematic review, and peer-reviewed sources

Last reviewed: May 2026

## The Emotional Side of Hearing Loss

### Hearing loss can affect how you feel

Hearing loss does not only affect what you hear. It can also affect how you feel, how much energy conversations take, how confident you feel around other people, and how connected you feel in daily life.

Many adults with hearing loss feel frustrated when they miss words, embarrassed when they misunderstand, or tired after trying to follow conversations. Some people avoid restaurants, family gatherings, meetings, phone calls, or group conversations because listening feels too difficult.

These reactions are understandable. Hearing loss can make communication harder, especially in background noise, when speech is fast, when people talk from another room, or when several people talk at the same time.

The emotional side of hearing loss is real, and it deserves attention.

### You are not “just being difficult”

People with hearing loss are sometimes misunderstood. Family members, friends, or coworkers may think the person is ignoring them, not paying attention, or “hearing only what they want to hear.”

This can be painful because hearing loss is not selective listening. A person may hear well in one situation and struggle in another. Listening depends on background noise, distance, lighting, room acoustics, whether the speaker is facing the listener, the speaker’s voice, and how tired the listener is.

You may hear someone talking but miss the words. You may hear well in a quiet room but struggle in a noisy restaurant. You may understand one speaker but miss another. These differences are common in hearing loss.

A helpful way to explain this is:

“I can hear that you are talking, but I cannot always understand the words clearly.”

### Why hearing loss can feel frustrating

Hearing loss can create repeated communication breakdowns. Over time, these moments can become emotionally exhausting.

You may feel frustrated when:

- People speak from another room

- People say “never mind”
- You miss the joke or the topic change
- You misunderstand a question
- You answer incorrectly because you misheard
- You miss names, numbers, or appointment details
- You ask for repetition several times
- Others seem impatient
- You feel like you are working harder than everyone else to follow the conversation

Frustration does not mean you are handling hearing loss poorly. It often means the listening situation is difficult and the communication supports are not enough.

## **Listening fatigue is real**

Listening with hearing loss can take extra effort. When speech is unclear or incomplete, the brain has to work harder to fill in missing information. This extra effort can make conversations tiring.

You may notice listening fatigue after:

- Long conversations
- Work meetings
- Phone calls
- Medical appointments
- Family gatherings
- Restaurants
- Religious or community events
- Video calls
- Noisy stores or public places

Listening fatigue may feel like mental tiredness, irritability, reduced patience, headache, stress, or wanting quiet after a long listening day.

This is not laziness. It is a common response when listening requires more effort than usual.

## **Hearing loss can affect confidence**

Hearing loss can affect confidence in social situations. Some adults worry about answering incorrectly, missing important information, asking people to repeat too often, or being judged by others.

You may notice thoughts such as:

- “What if I misunderstand?”

- “What if I answer the wrong question?”
- “What if people get annoyed?”
- “What if I miss something important?”
- “What if I cannot keep up?”
- “What if people think I am rude?”
- “What if I look older because I need hearing aids?”

These worries are common, but they can make people less likely to participate. Over time, a person may become quieter in groups or avoid difficult listening situations.

Confidence can improve when you have the right tools, strategies, and support.

## **Hearing loss can affect relationships**

Hearing loss can create stress in relationships. Communication partners may feel frustrated when they have to repeat. The person with hearing loss may feel embarrassed, blamed, or left out.

Common relationship challenges include:

- Misunderstandings
- Repeated requests for repetition
- Arguments about television volume
- Frustration when people speak from another room
- Missing emotional tone or small details
- Less participation in group conversations
- Avoiding social events together
- Family members acting as “interpreters”
- Feeling dependent on others for communication

These challenges are not the fault of one person. Hearing loss changes the communication situation for everyone involved.

Adult aural rehabilitation often includes counseling, education, communication strategies, hearing technology, and support for communication partners (American Speech-Language-Hearing Association [ASHA], n.d.).

Communication usually improves when both the person with hearing loss and their communication partners make changes.

## **Hearing loss and social withdrawal**

Some adults begin to avoid situations where hearing is difficult. This may happen slowly. A person may start skipping restaurants, avoiding group gatherings, staying quiet at family events, or choosing not to attend community activities.

Avoidance can feel protective at first. It reduces the stress of missing words or feeling embarrassed. But over time, it may reduce connection, participation, and quality of life.

A systematic review by Shukla and colleagues found that hearing loss is associated with loneliness and social isolation in older adults. This does not mean that every person with hearing loss will become lonely or isolated. It means hearing loss can create barriers to communication and participation, especially when it is not addressed.

A balanced message is important: hearing loss may increase the risk of social disconnection, but support, strategies, hearing technology, and communication partner education can help.

## **Hearing loss and mood**

Research has found an association between hearing loss and depression in older adults. In a systematic review and meta-analysis, Lawrence and colleagues found that hearing loss was associated with greater odds of depression in older adults.

This does not mean hearing loss automatically causes depression. Mood is affected by many factors, including health, sleep, stress, pain, social connection, finances, grief, medical conditions, medications, and life changes.

However, hearing loss can add stress by making daily communication harder. If you feel persistently sad, hopeless, anxious, isolated, or no longer interested in activities you used to enjoy, it is important to tell a healthcare professional.

Hearing care can support communication and participation, but emotional health may also need support from a primary care provider, counselor, psychologist, psychiatrist, support group, or trusted healthcare professional.

## **It is okay to grieve changes in hearing**

Some adults feel grief after learning they have hearing loss. This can happen even when the hearing loss is mild or even when treatment options are available.

You may grieve:

- Ease of conversation
- Music clarity
- Spontaneous social interaction
- Confidence in groups
- Hearing loved ones clearly
- Independence in certain settings
- The feeling that communication used to be simple

Grief does not mean you are overreacting. It means hearing is connected to relationships, identity, comfort, and daily life.

It is possible to feel grief and still move forward with support.

## Hearing aids and emotions

Hearing aids can bring mixed emotions. Some people feel relief. Some feel nervous. Some feel embarrassed. Some feel disappointed if hearing aids do not sound natural right away. Some feel frustrated during the adjustment period.

These reactions are common.

Hearing aids can improve access to speech and sound, but they do not restore normal hearing. They also take time, practice, and follow-up care. NIDCD explains that hearing aids take time and patience to use successfully and that regular use helps people adjust to them.

If hearing aids feel emotionally difficult, it may help to remember:

- Hearing aids are tools, not a sign of weakness.
- Many adults need hearing technology.
- Adjustment takes time.
- Follow-up appointments can improve comfort and sound quality.
- Hearing aids work best with communication strategies.
- Your feelings about hearing aids can change as you gain confidence.

## Self-advocacy can reduce stress

Self-advocacy means explaining what helps you communicate. It does not mean being demanding. It means giving others clear information so conversations can go better.

Helpful phrases include:

- “Please face me when you speak.”
- “I heard part of that, but I missed the last sentence.”
- “Can you say that another way?”
- “Can we move somewhere quieter?”
- “Please do not speak from another room.”
- “Can you write that down?”
- “Let me repeat that back to make sure I understood.”
- “I want to be included, but I need people to speak one at a time.”

Self-advocacy can feel uncomfortable at first, but it often reduces frustration and misunderstandings.

## Support from others matters

Support can come from many places, including:

- Audiologists

- Physicians or ear, nose, and throat specialists
- Family members
- Friends
- Coworkers
- Caregivers
- Support groups
- Mental health professionals
- Community organizations
- Hearing-loss education programs

Some people benefit from bringing a communication partner to audiology appointments. This can help family members understand hearing loss, learn communication strategies, and support hearing technology use.

A hearing care plan should include the person's real-life communication goals, not only hearing test results.

## **When to seek extra support**

Consider talking with a healthcare professional if hearing loss is affecting your emotional well-being.

It may be time to seek extra support if you:

- Feel sad or hopeless often
- Feel anxious before social situations
- Avoid people or activities you used to enjoy
- Feel isolated or disconnected
- Feel embarrassed most of the time
- Stop participating in conversations
- Feel unusually irritable or tired from listening
- Have conflict with family because of communication
- Feel overwhelmed by hearing aids or hearing loss
- Have thoughts of self-harm or not wanting to live

If you have thoughts of self-harm or feel unsafe, seek immediate help from emergency services, a crisis line, or a trusted healthcare professional.

Asking for help is not a failure. Emotional support is part of whole-person hearing care.

## **What can help emotionally?**

The right support depends on the person, but helpful steps may include:



- Learning about your hearing loss
- Using hearing aids or other technology when appropriate
- Attending follow-up appointments
- Practicing communication strategies
- Teaching family and friends what helps
- Using captions and written support
- Planning ahead for difficult listening situations
- Taking listening breaks
- Joining a hearing-loss support group
- Speaking with a counselor or mental health provider when needed
- Setting realistic goals with your audiologist

Small changes can make daily communication feel more manageable.

## **A balanced way to think about hearing loss**

Hearing loss can be difficult, but it does not define you. It is one part of your health and communication needs.

A balanced message is:

- Hearing loss can make communication harder.
- Difficult communication can affect confidence, relationships, and emotional well-being.
- These effects are real and valid.
- Support is available.
- Hearing technology, communication strategies, counseling, family education, and self-advocacy can help.
- The goal is not perfect hearing. The goal is better communication, participation, and quality of life.

## **Key Takeaway**

Hearing loss can affect emotions, confidence, relationships, listening energy, and social participation. Feeling frustrated, embarrassed, tired, or discouraged does not mean you are weak. It means hearing loss can make daily communication harder. Support from audiologists, family, communication partners, technology, communication strategies, and mental health professionals when needed can help you stay connected and participate more fully in daily life.

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# Your Personal Hearing Care Plan

Category: Live Well Long-Term

Best for: Adults with hearing loss, hearing aid users, adults preparing for follow-up care, family members

Evidence level: Professional, public health, and clinical guideline sources

Last reviewed: May 2026

## Your Personal Hearing Care Plan

### Why you need a hearing care plan

Hearing loss is not managed in one appointment. It is usually managed over time. Your hearing needs may change as your hearing changes, your daily routines change, your technology changes, or your listening environments become more demanding.

A personal hearing care plan helps you organize:

- What type of hearing loss you have
- What situations are hardest for you
- What technology you use
- What communication strategies help
- What follow-up care you need
- What medical concerns should be monitored
- What goals matter most in your daily life

The goal is not only to hear more sound. The goal is to communicate more confidently, participate more fully, reduce listening stress, and stay connected to the people and activities that matter to you.

### Step 1: Understand your hearing results

Your hearing care plan starts with understanding your hearing test results. Your audiologist may explain:

- Your type of hearing loss
- Your degree of hearing loss
- Whether one ear hears better than the other
- Which pitches are easiest or hardest for you to hear
- Your word recognition scores
- Whether medical referral is recommended
- Whether hearing aids or other technology may help
- How often your hearing should be monitored

You do not need to memorize every detail of your audiogram, but you should understand the main message.

Helpful questions to ask:

- What type of hearing loss do I have?
- Is my hearing loss temporary or permanent?
- Is one ear worse than the other?
- Which sounds am I missing?
- How does this explain my real-life hearing problems?
- How are my word recognition scores?
- Do I need medical follow-up?
- What are my best treatment or support options?

Understanding your results helps you make informed decisions.

## **Step 2: Identify your real-life listening goals**

A hearing test shows how you hear in the clinic. Your hearing goals show how hearing loss affects your real life.

Your goals may include:

- Hearing your spouse or partner more clearly
- Following family conversations
- Understanding grandchildren or children
- Hearing better at work
- Participating in meetings
- Understanding phone calls
- Watching television at a comfortable volume
- Hearing better in restaurants
- Following medical appointments
- Feeling safer with alerts and environmental sounds
- Feeling less tired from listening
- Feeling more confident in social situations

Your audiologist can use these goals to help guide hearing aid settings, assistive technology recommendations, communication strategies, and follow-up care.

A useful goal is specific.

Instead of:

“I want to hear better.”

Try:

“I want to understand my family better at dinner when several people are talking.”

or:

“I want to hear better during work meetings when speakers are across the room.”

Specific goals lead to better planning.

### **Step 3: Know your hearing technology options**

Hearing technology may include hearing aids, assistive listening devices, captioning tools, alerting devices, or implantable hearing options for some people.

Not every adult needs every tool. The best technology depends on your hearing test results, lifestyle, communication needs, physical comfort, technology comfort, budget, and personal goals.

Common options include:

- Prescription hearing aids
- Over-the-counter hearing aids for some adults with perceived mild to moderate hearing loss
- Remote microphones
- TV streamers
- Phone streaming
- Captioned phones
- Smartphone captioning tools
- Video-call captions
- Visual or vibrating alerting devices
- Public assistive listening systems
- Telecoil or hearing loop access
- Cochlear implant evaluation when appropriate

Hearing technology should be matched to the problem you are trying to solve.

For example:

- If phone calls are difficult, you may need Bluetooth streaming, captions, or a captioned phone.
- If television is difficult, you may need captions, a TV streamer, or wireless TV headphones.
- If meetings are difficult, you may need captions, a remote microphone, written notes, or better seating.
- If alarms are difficult, you may need visual or vibrating alerting devices.
- If hearing aids are not enough, your audiologist may discuss additional testing or other hearing technology options.

## **Step 4: Use communication strategies**

Technology helps, but communication strategies are still important. Hearing aids and assistive devices work best when the listening situation is also improved.

Helpful strategies include:

- Face the speaker
- Move closer
- Reduce background noise
- Improve lighting
- Ask people not to speak from another room
- Ask for rephrasing instead of only repetition
- Ask people to speak one at a time
- Repeat back important information
- Use written instructions for important details
- Use captions when available
- Plan ahead for difficult listening situations
- Tell others what helps you hear

Communication should not be the responsibility of only the person with hearing loss. Family, friends, coworkers, caregivers, and healthcare providers can also help by using clear communication habits.

## **Step 5: Plan your follow-up care**

Hearing care usually requires follow-up. This is especially true if you use hearing aids or other hearing technology.

Follow-up appointments may include:

- Reviewing your hearing goals
- Adjusting hearing aid programming
- Checking physical comfort
- Checking hearing aid function
- Reviewing cleaning and maintenance
- Reviewing phone, TV, or Bluetooth use
- Discussing background-noise problems
- Considering remote microphones or accessories
- Updating your hearing care plan
- Repeating hearing testing when needed

Bring specific examples to your follow-up appointments.

Examples:

- “Restaurants are still difficult.”
- “My own voice sounds hollow.”
- “The right hearing aid feels loose.”
- “I hear better at home, but meetings are still hard.”
- “Phone calls are unclear.”
- “I need help connecting to my TV.”
- “I feel tired after wearing the hearing aids all day.”
- “I miss public announcements.”

Specific feedback helps your audiologist make more targeted recommendations.

## **Step 6: Know when to seek medical care**

Some hearing symptoms should be evaluated medically. Hearing aids and communication strategies should not be used to ignore possible medical warning signs.

Contact a healthcare provider, audiologist, or ear, nose, and throat specialist if you notice:

- Sudden hearing loss
- A sudden change in hearing
- Hearing loss in only one ear
- A major difference between ears
- Ear pain
- Ear drainage
- Dizziness or vertigo
- New or one-sided tinnitus
- Ear fullness that does not go away
- Hearing loss after head injury
- A foreign object in the ear
- Earwax blockage that you cannot safely manage
- Hearing that changes quickly

If symptoms are sudden or severe, seek urgent medical guidance.

## **Step 7: Protect the hearing you have**

Hearing protection is part of long-term hearing care. Loud sound exposure can damage hearing. This can happen from very loud sounds over a short time or from repeated loud sound exposure over time.

Common loud sound sources include:

- Concerts
- Power tools
- Firearms
- Motorcycles
- Loud music
- Sirens
- Sporting events
- Certain workplaces
- Yard equipment
- Headphones or earbuds at high volume

Ways to protect your hearing include:

- Use earplugs or earmuffs in loud places
- Use custom hearing protection when appropriate
- Keep headphone volume at a safer level
- Take breaks from loud sound
- Move away from loudspeakers
- Follow workplace hearing protection rules
- Ask your audiologist about hearing protection that fits your needs

If you already have hearing loss, protecting your remaining hearing is especially important.

## **Step 8: Include family or communication partners**

A hearing care plan is often more successful when important communication partners are included. This may include a spouse, partner, adult child, friend, caregiver, or coworker.

Communication partners can help by:

- Learning about your hearing loss
- Facing you when speaking
- Reducing background noise
- Rephrasing instead of saying “never mind”
- Speaking one at a time in groups



- Writing down important details
- Helping track hearing aid concerns
- Attending appointments if you want them there
- Supporting use of hearing technology
- Respecting your communication needs

You should decide who you want involved in your care.

A helpful phrase is:

“I am working on my hearing care plan. It would help me if we used a few communication strategies together.”

## **Step 9: Track changes over time**

Your hearing and communication needs may change. Tracking changes can help you know when to return for care.

Pay attention to:

- Asking for repetition more often
- Turning up the television more than before
- Having more difficulty in noise
- Having more difficulty on the phone
- Avoiding social situations
- Feeling more tired from listening
- Hearing aids not helping as much as before
- New tinnitus
- New dizziness or imbalance
- New ear pain, pressure, or drainage
- Family members noticing more difficulty

If you notice changes, schedule follow-up care. Do not wait until communication becomes very difficult.

## **Step 10: Review your plan regularly**

Your hearing care plan should be reviewed regularly. You may review it:

- After a hearing test
- After a hearing aid fitting
- After follow-up appointments
- When your hearing changes
- When your daily routine changes

- When your work or school demands change
- When you have new communication goals
- When technology becomes difficult to use
- When family members notice new concerns

Your plan should stay practical and personal. It should answer:

- What is my hearing status?
- What are my goals?
- What tools am I using?
- What still feels difficult?
- What support do I need next?
- When should I follow up?

A hearing care plan is not a one-time worksheet. It is a guide you can update over time.

## **What a strong hearing care plan includes**

A strong hearing care plan includes:

- Current hearing test results
- Main listening goals
- Hearing technology plan
- Communication strategy plan
- Follow-up schedule
- Medical referral plan if needed
- Hearing protection plan
- Family or communication partner plan
- Assistive technology plan
- Questions for the audiologist
- A way to track changes over time

This kind of plan helps turn hearing care into daily-life support.

## **Questions to ask at future appointments**

At future appointments, you may ask:

- Has my hearing changed?
- Are my hearing aids still programmed appropriately?

- Are my hearing aids working properly?
- Should my hearing aids be verified or adjusted?
- Are my word recognition scores stable?
- Do I need medical referral?
- Would assistive listening technology help me?
- Would a remote microphone help in noise?
- What can help with phone calls?
- What can help with television?
- What can help with meetings or restaurants?
- How often should I return for hearing testing?
- What symptoms should I report right away?
- Do I need hearing protection?
- Are there newer options that fit my needs?

Writing questions down before the appointment can help you remember what matters most.

## **A balanced long-term message**

Living with hearing loss does not mean giving up important parts of life. It means learning what supports help you communicate, participate, and stay connected.

A balanced hearing care plan recognizes that:

- Hearing loss can affect daily communication.
- Hearing aids and technology can help, but they have limits.
- Communication strategies are important.
- Family and communication partners matter.
- Follow-up care improves outcomes.
- Some symptoms need medical attention.
- Hearing protection matters.
- Emotional well-being matters.
- Your goals should guide the plan.

The goal is not perfect hearing. The goal is better access, better communication, and better participation in daily life.

## **Key Takeaway**

A personal hearing care plan helps you organize your hearing results, listening goals, technology, communication strategies, follow-up care, and long-term support. Hearing care is not a single appointment. It is an ongoing process that should fit your hearing, your life, and your goals.

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